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Vaishno Devi Temple

Vaishno Devi Temple, also known as the **Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Temple** and **Vaishno Devi Bhavan**, is a Hindu temple in Katra, Reasi district, Jammu and Kashmir, India. Dedicated to Vaishno Devi, a manifestation of godesses Mahakali, Mahalakshmi, and Mahasarasvati,[1][2][3][4] it is on Trikuta mountain at an elevation of 5,200 feet (1,500 meters).[5] The Shakti tradition considers it to be a Shakti Pitha.[6] The temple is 43 km from the main city of Jammu and 29 km from the district headquarters Reasi town. The temple is governed by the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine Board (SMVDSB) and has been chaired by the Governor of Jammu and Kashmir since August 1986.[7]

It is one of the most popular Hindu pilgrimage sites in India, with millions of devotees visiting the temple annually.[8] In 2023 SMVDSB reported 9.52 million pilgrims.[9]

Vaishno Devi Temple

View of Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Bhavan surrounded by Trikuta Hills

Religion	
Affiliation	Hinduism
District	Reasi
Deity	Vaishno Devi
Festivals	Navaratri, Diwali, New Year
Governing body	Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine Board
Location	
Location	Katra, Jammu and Kashmir
State	Jammu and Kashmir
Country	India

Location of Vaishno Devi in Jammu & Kashmir

History

Although the Vaishno Devi temple is now the most popular Devi shrine in the region, its popularity is relatively recent.

In 1971, when Inderjit Bhardwaj did a study of Devi shrines in the Siwalik mountains, he did not mention the Vaishno Devi temple as particularly important.. Its popularity increased rapidly after an expansion was done in 1976 so that it could accommodate up to 5,000 visitors per day. By 1981, annual visitors to the shrine were about 900,000; by the early 1990s, the number had increased to over 3 million, and the Vaishno Devi temple had become by far the most popular Devi temple in the region. By 2007, the annual number of pilgrims was about 7.5 million. In June 2007, in order to reduce congestion and improve security, the Shrine Board reduced the limit on the number of visitors allowed per month.[10]:110,16

The Vaishno Devi temple was in existence by 1846, when Maharaja Gulab Singh established the Dharmarth Trust to manage several temples in his territory; the Vaishno Devi temple was part of this trust. The trust remained in the hands of Gulab Singh's descendants after independence, and his descendant Karan Singh was responsible for administering the temple as the hereditary trustee until 1986, when Jagmohan, then governor of Jammu and Kashmir, passed legislation transferring control of the Vaishno Devi temple from the Dharmarth Trust and the hereditary priests to a separate Shrine Board.[10]:114–5

Vaishno Devi Temple (India)

Interactive map of Vaishno Devi Temple

Coordinates	33.0299°N 74.9482°E
Architecture	
Type	Cave Temple
Completed	0028 Vikram Samvat
Specifications	
Temple	4
Elevation	1,584.96 m (5,200 ft)
Website	
maavaishnodevi.org (https://www.maavaishnodevi.org/)	

Legends

The temple, at a height of 1,585 metres (5,200 ft) is 12 km from Katra on Trikuta hill. It is about 61 km from Jammu city.[11][12] A geological study of the Holy Cave has indicated its age to be nearly a million years. There is also a mention of the Trikuta hill in Rigveda, the place where the temple is located.[13]

The *Mahabharata*, which gives the account of the Pandavas and the Kurukshetra War, does mention the worship of goddess Vaishno Devi. Before the Kurukshetra War Arjuna is said to have worshipped Durga by the advice of Lord Krishna for the blessings. Pleased by his devotion, Mother Goddess appeared in front of him in the form of Vaishno Devi. When goddess appeared, Arjuna started praising her with a stotra, in which a Shloka goes by saying ‘ *Jambookatak Chityaishu Nityam Sannihitalaye* ’, which means ‘you who always dwell in the temple on the slope of the mountain in Jambhu’ — probably referring to the present day Jammu.[14] Former Governor of Jammu and Kashmir Jagmohan says, "the Mata Vaishno Devi shrine is an ancient one whose antiquity is pre-Mahabharathan, Lord Krishna is believed to have advised Arjuna to go up in the hills of 'Jambhu' and seek the blessings of Vaishno Devi before taking up arms in the battlefield. 'Jambhu' is identified with present-day Jammu. Arjuna while worshipping Vaishno Devi, calls her highest yogi who is free from decrepitude and decay, who is the Mother of the Vedas and the Science of Vedanta and who is giver of Victory and personification of victory itself".[15] It is also generally believed that the Pandavas were the first to build the temples

Mata Vaishno Devi Pindi at the holy shrine

at Kol Kandoli and Bhawan in reverence and gratitude for the Mother Goddess. On a mountain, just adjacent to the Trikuta Mountain and overlooking the Holy Cave are five stone structures, which are believed to be the rock symbols of the five Pandavas.[16][17][18]

Encounter with Rama

As per the temple's legend, Goddess Vaishnavi once met Lord Rama in the forests of Trikuta Hills during his exile. She expressed her wish to marry him, but Rama, bound by his vow of having only one wife and already being wedded to Sita, declined. However, he promises that he would return to her in the form of Kalki, the 10th incarnation of Vishnu, who would be born in Kali Yuga, and marry her then. Rama asked her to continue her penance in the cave of Manik (Trikuta) mountains, meditating and blessing devotees until the arrival of Kalki. As per Rama's order, Vaishnavi took residence in the holy cave where Mahakali, Mahalakshmi Vaishnavi, and Mahasaraswati reside, where she is now worshipped as Vaishno Devi.[19] The *Lakshmi Narayan Samhita* (1.334.53) and *Dvaparayuga Santana* (3.237.154) identified Maniki as the consort or Shakti of Kalki. [20]

The discovery of the shrine by Pandit Shridhar

While various versions of the origin and legend of Shri Mata Vaishno Devi are prevalent, there is unanimity on the discovery of Shrine around 700 years back by the Pandit Shridhar, at whose place Mata Vaishno had helped organize a Bhandaara. When she left amidst the Bhandaara to escape Bhairon Nath, Pandit Shridhar is said to have felt as if he had lost everything in his life. He felt immense grief and gave up the intake of food or even water and closed himself in a room of his house, fervently praying for Vaishnavi to reappear.

It is then that Mata Vaishnavi appeared in his vision (dream) and told him to search for her at the Holy Cave situated amidst the folds of the Trikuta Mountain. She showed him the way to the Holy Cave and insisted him to break his fast. Pandit Shridhar then went on to discover the Holy Cave in the mountains. Every time he seemed to lose the way, the vision of his dreams reappeared before his eyes and finally he reached his destination. Upon entering the Cave he found a rock form with three heads atop it. At that moment Mata Vaishno Devi appeared before him in all her glory (another version says that the Supreme Energies of Mata Maha Saraswati, Mata Maha Lakshmi and Mata Maha Kali appeared in the Holy Cave) and introduced him to the three heads (now known as the Holy Pindies) of the rock form along with various other identification marks in the Holy Cave. She blessed him with a boon of four sons and a right to worship her manifestation and asked him to spread the glory of the Holy Shrine all over. Pandit Shridhar then spent his remaining life in the service of Mata at the Holy Cave.[21]

Vaishno Devi Bhawan during winters

A still from the play "Mata Ki Kahani" depicting the legend of Mata Vaishno Devi, written by playwright Padma Shri Balwant Thakur.

The story of Bhairon Nath

It is said that Bhairon Nath, a famous Hindu Tantric, saw the young Vaishno Devi at an agricultural fair and fell madly in love with her. Vaishno Devi fled into Trikuta hills to escape his amorous advances, later she turned into her original form of Durga and cut off his head with her sword in a cave.[22] The place where his severed head fell is now called the Bhairon Ghati, which has a temple dedicated to him.

Bhairon Nath Temple, where the head of Bhairon Nath fell on hill

According to author Manohar Sajnani, some legends hold that the original abode of Vaishno Devi was Ardh Kunwari, a place about 6 km[23] between Katra town and the cave.

The Holy Cave of Vaishno Devi

The Holy Cave, located at the summit of Trikuta Mountain and known as the Bhawan, serves as the pilgrimage's ultimate sanctum. Measuring approximately 98 feet in length, it is a natural limestone cavern housing intricate rock formations revered by devotees as swayambhu (self-manifested) embodiments of divine figures and symbols. These speleothems (stalactites and stalagmites formed over millennia) interweave geology with mythology, transforming the cave into a living narrative of the Goddess's legend.[24][25]

The Entrance: Bhairavnath’s Body and the Legend of Moksha

The cave's mouth is indelibly linked to the myth of Bhairavnath, the tantric sage-turned-demon whose pursuit of the Goddess culminates in his demise. As per the lore, Vaishnavi beheaded Bhairavnath with her sword at the cave's threshold; the immense force propelled his severed head to Bhairav Ghati, a hilltop shrine 1.5 to 3 kilometers distant, while his torso remained petrified at the entrance as a massive 14-foot rock slab.[26][27][28]

In his final breaths, Bhairavnath attained remorse and enlightenment, prompting the Goddess to bestow moksha (liberation) upon him. She decreed that no yatra would attain fruition without homage at his Bhairav Ghati temple, embedding a lesson in humility and redemption.[26][27][28] Pilgrims ritually step over this "torso" rock to enter, a symbolic transcendence of ego and sin (echoing the demon's defeat) as they approach the divine presence.[29]

Hanuman (Launkra Beer)

The first guardian encountered is Launkra Beer (or Vir Langur), a stalagmite evoking Lord Hanuman's vigilant form. Tradition holds that Hanuman stood sentinel during the Goddess's penance, embodying unwavering devotion and protection as the cave's eternal dwarpal (doorkeeper).[30][29][31]

The Charan Ganga

A perennial stream of frigid, crystalline water (the Charan Ganga) courses through the cavern, purportedly springing from the feet (charan) of the Pindis themselves. Devotees wade through its purifying flow (charanamrit) in the traditional darshan path, a baptismal rite cleansing body and soul before the sanctum.[25][30][29]

Sher Ka Panja (The Lion’s Paw)

About 59 feet inward lies Sher Ka Panja, a striking imprint mimicking a lion's paw (the vahana of Vaishno Devi). This mark affirms the Goddess's triumphant Shakti, her mount ever at paw's reach.[30][29]

Shesh Nag and the Roof

Further along, roughly 72 to 73 feet in, the ceiling expands into a hooded expanse resembling Shesh Nag, the thousand-headed serpent sustaining the cosmos. Here, the mythic naga symbolically upholds the cavern's vault, mirroring Vishnu's eternal repose on the serpent's coils.[30][29]

Symbols of Vishnu

Beneath Shesh Nag, the Havan Kund area features Vishnu's iconic emblems carved by nature: the conch (Shankh) for cosmic sound, discus (Chakra) for preservation, mace (Gada) for retribution, and lotus (Padam) for purity. These affirm Vaishno Devi as Vishnu's tantric Shakti, bridging Vaishnava and Shakta realms.[30][29]

Prahlad’s Pillar

Adjacent stands Prahlad's Khamba, a columnar stalagmite honoring the boy-devotee of Vishnu whose faith felled Hiranyakashipu. It evokes unyielding bhakti amid trials.[30][29]

Presence of Shiva

Subtler Shaiva echoes appear 6 feet beyond: faint rock visages of Shankar (Shiva) and Gauri (Parvati) on the left wall. Some traditions discern a recumbent Shiva figure with the Goddess's foot upon him, evoking Ardhanarishvara or Kali's tantric dominion over the supine lord.[29][31]

The Sanctum Sanctorum: The Three Pindis

The cave's heart enshrines the three Pindis (amorphous, swayambhu rock masses emerging from a marble base), manifestations of the Trimurti's feminine counterparts. No anthropomorphic idols adorn them; their raw forms embody the Goddess's ineffable essence.[26]

- **Maha Kali** (right): Jet-black, channeling tamas (raw power and demon-slaying fury).
- **Maha Lakshmi** (center): Golden-red, radiating rajas (prosperity, preservation, and Vaishno Devi's core vitality).
- **Maha Saraswati** (left): Alabaster-white, embodying sattva (knowledge, creation, and serene wisdom).[32]

The triad's geometry evokes the Shri Yantra's central bindu and triangles, with the Pindis as focal energies for tantric meditation (though a literal inscribed yantra graces a nearby submerged rock).[30] Due to the constant worship over so many centuries, the rocks are eroding and losing their colour.

Natural Phenomenon

Geologically, the Holy Cave is a million-year-old karst feature in the Trikuta limestone range, sculpted by groundwater dissolution. Its speleothems arise from mineral precipitation, while the Charan Ganga sustains as a vital aquifer-fed spring. Devotees behold these as prakriti’s divine artistry, where science and

shraddha converge in eternal harmony.[24][25]

Shakti Peetha

Vaishno Devi Gufa (also known as **Vaishno Devi Bhawan**) is one of the 108 Shakti Peethas, sacred sites dedicated to the worship of Shakti, the divine feminine energy in Hinduism. According to scholarly articles, two primary traditions circulate regarding the origin of this peetha. The first asserts that the "skull of Mata Sati fell here," establishing the shrine as the "holiest of all Shaktipeeths."[33] A competing tradition claims that it was Sati's "right arm" that fell at the site.[33] This "right arm" narrative faces active contestation, with scholarly sources noting that "some scriptures do not agree" and proposing instead that "Gandarbal in Kashmir is the place where the right arm of Sati had fallen."[33]

For devotees, the "right arm" claim gains strong substantiation from a distinctive physical feature inside the holy cave: "stone remains of a human hand," popularly interpreted as *Varad Hast* (the hand that grants boons and blessings) or *Abhaya Hasta* (the gesture of succour).[33] This natural rock formation is viewed as a tangible manifestation of the mythological event, providing material evidence that bolsters the tradition among pilgrims.

Scholarly analysis

- **Diana L. Eck:** In her 2012 book *India: A Sacred Geography*, Harvard Indologist Diana L. Eck portrays the Vaishno Devi shrine as a crucial node in the expansive sacred landscape of India.[34] Eck vividly describes the goddess taking residence on "Trikuta, the Triple Peak," where she "hollowed out a cave there with her trident."[35]

Eck further delves into a compelling psycho-ritual reading of the pilgrimage experience, emphasizing the transformative symbolism of navigating the cave. She observes that pilgrims must "squeeze... One by one they crawl through the passageway... The ritual crawl has all the symbolism of gestation and birth," evoking themes of rebirth and divine emergence.[36][35]

- **Abha Chauhan:** In her 2011 sociological study *Sacred Landscape and Pilgrimage: A Study of Mata Vaishno Devi*, Abha Chauhan examines the pilgrimage route as a "sacred landscape" in its own right.[37] Her analysis highlights the ritualistic and cultural significance of key stops along the trek, such as Himkoti and Sanji Chhat, portraying them as integral elements of a holistic spatial and performative experience that transforms the journey into a profound act of devotion.[38]

Deities

The three icons — Mahakali, Mahalakshmi and Mahasaraswati, all images of Vaishno Devi are worshipped at the temple. The feet of the icons are washed by the water brought from the perennial flowing river Charan Ganga.[39]

Worship

The icons of Mahalakshmi, Mahakali and Mahasaraswati in the temple

Author Pintchman identifies with great goddess Mahadevi and says Vaishno Devi contains all powers and is associated with the entire creation as Mahadevi.[40] Author Pintchman also says that, "Pilgrims identify Vaishno Devi with the Goddess Durga— Dogras and Punjabis also use the epithet *Seranwali*, "the Lion-rider"— while referring to her.[40] The temple is sacred to both Hindus and Sikhs. Many prominent saints such as Swami Vivekananda have visited the temple.[41]

The temple receives an estimated annual $16 million according to some authors[42] and has received over 1,800 kg of gold, 4,700 kilos of silver, and ₹2,000 crore (US$240 million) cash in the last two decades (2000–2020) as donation.[43]

Mata Vaishno Devi Bhawan illuminated with facade lighting

Festivals

The most prominent festivals held at Vaishno Devi Temple are Navaratri, a nine nights festival celebrating Devi's victory over evil demons and Diwali, a festival of lights symbolizing the victory of light over darkness, good over evil, and knowledge over ignorance.[44][45][46]

The Navaratri festival is a festival celebrated during the month of Ashvin, which typically falls in the Gregorian months of September and October.[47]

Vaishno Devi Bhawan cave area decorated during Navratris

Administration

The Vaishno Devi Temple was included in the Jammu and Kashmir Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine Act No. XVI/1988 and also part of Article 26 of the Constitution of India.[48] The name of the administrating and governing board is the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine Board. There are nine members in the board; all are nominated by the Government of Jammu and Kashmir, particularly by Lieutenant Governor of Jammu and Kashmir. The Governor of Jammu and Kashmir is the ex-officio chairman of the board.[49] In 1991, Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine Board management also took the control of Shiv Khori, a famous Shiva temple, [50] but administration of the Shiv Khori temple has since been handed over to a separate shrine board in 2008, namely Shiv Khori Shrine Board,[51] with SMVDSB only serving an ex-officio role.

The quantitative impact of the 1986 administrative takeover is stark and verifiable from official board data cited in academic research.

- **Pilgrim Growth**: The number of pilgrims visiting the shrine grew exponentially. In 1986, the year of the takeover, the number of pilgrims was recorded at 13.96 lakhs (1.396 million). By 2011, this number had increased more than sevenfold to 101.15 lakhs (10.115 million).[52]
- **Demographic Profile**: The nature of this pilgrimage is overwhelmingly non-local. Data from the early 2000s (2000-2006) shows a stable demographic ratio of approximately 87% non-local pilgrims (from outside Jammu and Kashmir) to 13% local pilgrims.[52]
- **Socio-Economic Impact**: This 87:13 ratio is the central driver of the pilgrimage's massive socio-economic impact. The 87% of "outside" pilgrims require multi-day lodging, food, and transportation, fueling the entire economy of the base town of Katra. The 13% of "local" pilgrims are more likely to be day-trippers who do not contribute to the same economic extent.[52][53][54][55][56]

The following nine members serve in the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine Board, as per the latest reconstitution in June 2025:[57]

Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine Board

Name	Position
Manoj Sinha, Lt. Governor of the UT of J&K	Chairperson (ex-officio)
Sudha Murty	Member
Mahamandaleshwar Shri Swami Vishveshvaranand Giriji Maharaj	Member
Ashok Bhan	Member
Baleshwar Rai	Member
Gunjan Rana	Member
Dr. K.K. Talwar	Member
Kulbhushan Ahuja	Member
Lalit Bhasin	Member
Suresh Kumar Sharma	Member

Activities by SMVDSB

The Shrine Board is responsible for governing and administring the entirety of the Mata Vaishno Devi tracks and temples. The temples under the board include the main Bhawan complex, the Ardhkuwari temple, the Bhairon temple, and the other temples on the tracks. [58]

For pilgrim comfort, the Shrine Board has established multiple guest houses and accommodation facilities. These include the Niharika complex, Aashirwad Bhawan, Trikuta Bhawan, and Shakti Bhawan at Katra. A Spiritual Growth Centre is also run by the Shrine Board in Katra whose facilities include an auditorium, conference hall, amphitheatre, and library. At Bhawan, the shrine board has developed the Kalika Bhawan, Shridhar Bhawan, Gauri Bhawan, Vaishnavi Bhawan, Manokamana Bhawans, Durga Bhawan, etc. for pilgrim accommodation. Multiple other accommodations are run by the board on the

tracks, such as the Shubhra Bhawan at Banganga and Bhawans at Ardhkuwari. In Jammu, the Shrine Board has constructed the Kalika Dham, Saraswati Dham, and Vaishnavi Dham near the Jammu Railway Station. The Shrine Board also runs a souvenier and prasad shop at the Jammu airport. [59][60][61][62]

SMVDSB chairman Manoj Sinha inaugurates integrated command and control centre at Katra

The Shrine Board has also constructed and maintains a sports complex in Katra town, which includes badminton and tennis courts along with a dedicated gymnasium and a sports stadium, which is the largest in Reasi district. The sports complex is well known for producing gifted sportspersons, like Sheetal Devi and Rakesh Kumar, both of whom won bronze medals at the Paris Paralympics in 2024. [63][64]

The Shrine Board is the patron of the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Narayana Super Speciality Hospital in Katra, which is run in collaboration with Narayana Healthcare.[65] The Shrine Board also runs a medical college, the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Institute of Medical Excellence[66] and a nursing institute, the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi College of Nursing at Katra town. The Shrine Board also oversees the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi University and runs a gurukul for secondary students at Banganga.[67][68][69]

The shrine board operates battery vehicle services on the Bhawan-Himkoti-Ardhkuwari route, especially for senior citizens and persons with disabilities who receive special quotas for the service. The shrine board also operates helipads at Sanjhichhat and Panchi on the yatra track and at Katra, allowing pilgrims to reach Bhawan via air. A cablecar service has been in operation since 2018 for transporting pilgrims along the Bhawan-Bhairon route. [70][71]

The shrine board also operates a nursery for plant conservation and undertakes drives for afforestation of the Trikuta hills. The shrine board also publishes a quarterly newsletter, Trikuta (https://www.maavaishnodevi.org/newsletter) to apprise the public of its developmental works and on yatra statistics. [72]

The primary challenge created by this mass pilgrimage is the extreme environmental stress on the Trikuta Hills, leading to significant geological and safety risks. A series of events in 2025 provides a verifiable case study of this central challenge and the Board's multi-pronged response. On August 26, 2025, a devastating landslide struck at Adhkuwari, a critical juncture on the Vaishno Devi pilgrimage route, claiming the lives of 35 pilgrims and underscoring the perilous terrain's vulnerability to natural hazards.[73] The tragedy prompted swift legal repercussions: a Jammu resident lodged a criminal complaint demanding the filing of a First Information Report (FIR) against officials of the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine Board (SMVDSB), including CEO Sachin Kumar Vaishya, on charges of "criminal negligence." The allegations centered on the Board's purported failure to issue advisories or halt the yatra despite explicit weather warnings and a "red alert" from the Meteorological Department and the Jammu and Kashmir Union Territory Disaster Management Authority (JKUTDMA).[73] In response, a Katra court directed the police to submit an "Action Taken Report," intensifying scrutiny on the shrine's disaster preparedness protocols.[73] Paradoxically, the incident unfolded amid the Board's proactive initiatives to address such geological risks. Just months earlier, on April 8, 2025, the SMVDSB entered into a tripartite Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) aimed at enhancing slope stability along the yatra route. The agreement involved the Shrine Board, THDC India Limited (THDCIL) as the technical consultant for geotechnical evaluations, and the Geological Survey of India (GSI) for comprehensive geological

surveys, signaling a forward-looking commitment to engineering safeguards.[74] Complementing these efforts, in June 2025, the Board issued an electronic Notice Inviting Tender (e-NIT) for an innovative afforestation drive leveraging drone technology. The project targets the seeding of 183 hectares across the "hard-to-reach terrains" of the Trikuta Hills, employing aerial seed dispersal to foster vegetation cover, combat soil erosion, and bolster environmental resilience in the ecologically fragile zone.[75] These measures reflect the ongoing tension between the shrine's surging popularity and the imperative for sustainable management amid a changing climate.

The executive tasks of the SMVDSB are conducted by a chief executive officer, additional chief executive officer, joint chief executive officer, deputy chief executive officer, assistant chief executive officers, multiple section heads and managers and supervisors. [76]

See also

- Shiv Khori Temple
- Kheer Bhawani Temple
- Amarnath
- Raghunath Temple
- Sharada Peeth
- Jammu
- Avantiswami Temple

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